forces, including those of China, North Korea, South Korea, India, and Japan; as well as three declared nuclear powers (five, if the United States and Russia are included). Through its strategic waterways, such as the Malacca and Sunda Straits, transit some 70 percent of global trade and some 75,000 ships annually, linking Asia with the Middle East and Europe.[3] By any measure, economic disruption, regional conflict, or even domestic destabilization of any of Asia's major nations could have far-reaching effects both regionally and globally.

Asia's importance to the United States has grown dramatically since the normalization of US-China ties in 1979, not least because more than seventeen million Americans are immigrants from Asia or have Asian heritage, making up 5.8 percent of the US population.[4] Add to that the hundreds of thousands of Chinese, Indians, Koreans, and Japanese studying or working in the United States, and America's grassroots connections to Asia have never been stronger. US trade in goods with Asia totals nearly $1.5 trillion dollars, nearly double that with Europe.[5] The United States also could very easily be drawn into any intra-Asian conflict, given not only its alliance commitments but its long history of Pacific engagement.

Early American Strategy in the Indo-Pacific

As a country born only in the late eighteenth century, the United States was a latecomer to the waters of the Indian and Pacific Oceans. European nations, starting with Portugal and followed by Spain, the Netherlands, and England, traded for centuries with Asian princely states, kingdoms, and islands. Eschewing the costly, land-based routes of the Silk Road, European sailors rounded the Cape of Good Hope and followed the sea-lanes long opened by Arab traders into the Indian Ocean. This incursion from the western edge of the Eurasian landmass led inexorably, if unexpectedly, to the establishment of colonial outposts to protect the European traders, primarily spice merchants, and their small settlements. Starting on the western coast of the Indian